Product / Project Translator



THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Find out what they need to decide. Give them a useful answer without promising work you cannot yet describe.

Nic Payne

For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

“Can you just give me the final requirements?”

Someone needs a feature list, a date, or a budget while you’re still finding things out. Let’s understand what they need the answer for, then work out what you can usefully offer now.

Find the decision behind the question

Finance may need to reserve money. Sales may need to tell a customer when to expect something. Another team may need to plan its work. Ask rather than guessing.

Say what you can answer now

If the work is understood and the team can give a reliable date, use it. If an important question is still open, explain exactly what it is.

Offer a useful next step

Perhaps you can agree to test two booking designs with customers in the next two weeks, then bring a build estimate to Finance. Name the work, the limit, and what they will be able to decide afterward.

Write a reply you would actually say

The Lab helps you check the request, prepare a commitment, and write the response. You don’t need to teach someone product-management vocabulary before helping them plan.

Try: “What do you need the feature list for? Which decision are you trying to make, and when do you need to make it?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

You can be frustrated and still be curious.

When someone asks for details you don't have yet, it can be hard to know what to say. They may be trying to make a decision of their own. Let's start by finding out what it is.

What actually happened?

Start with what was said or done. "They asked for Friday" tells us what happened. "They don't care about the team" is an explanation you may have added. What could you ask to find out what's behind the request?

Why do you care?

Who would be better off if this worked? Perhaps a customer could stop chasing an answer, or your team could finish something it promised. Say why that matters to you, and ask what matters to the other person too.

What would better look like?

Imagine the next few weeks going well. What would people be doing differently? Describe that in ordinary words, then ask the other person what they would add or change.

Keep these notes to yourself

These questions are for your own thinking; you can answer them without typing. If you use the Lab's private notes, they stay only in the open tab. They aren't saved or exported, and disappear when you refresh or leave.

An opening you can adapt: "I want us to find a way through this. Can we look at what is happening and work out what to do next?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What is the request helping them do?

“Final requirements” may sound like a demand for certainty. It may also be the language someone uses when they need to reserve money or coordinate another team.

Repeat the actual request

You need the final feature list before reserving next quarter’s budget. Have I got that right?

Ask what depends on it

Which decision do you need to make? What would happen if you didn’t have the full list by Thursday?

Check which details matter now

Do you need a spending limit, an estimate for the full build, or a commitment to particular features? Those are different answers.

Leave room to be corrected

I thought you needed every screen agreed. It sounds as though the immediate question is how much to set aside. What else do you need?

Use what they confirm. If you have not asked yet, keep it as a question rather than filling in their motives.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Ask what they will use the answer for.

You may have an idea of why they're asking. A quick question can help you check it before you spend time on the answer.

"We need final requirements"

"Which decision depends on that list? Do you need to reserve money, agree a contract, or get another team ready?" Find out which details need to be settled now.

"We need a firm date"

"Who is waiting for it, and what have they been told?" Ask the team for its current delivery estimate and what could change it.

"We need the full roadmap"

"How far ahead do you need to plan, and what will you use it for?" Explain which work is agreed, which is only a possibility, and when you'll know more.

Record what they actually confirm

If you haven't asked yet, jot down the question you want to ask. You can add their answer after you have spoken; for now, keep your guess separate from what they've confirmed.

You're looking for an answer that helps them make their decision. Check that you understand it before writing the response.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What can we promise at this point?

You can still give someone a useful answer while you're learning. Let's work out what you can do now, what it will help you find out, and when you'll come back to them.

Start with what you know

For example, customers currently phone to book repairs. There are two possible online designs. Neither has been tried with customers.

Name the question that matters

Can customers complete a booking using either design? How much work would the better one take to build? Say how you'll find out.

Propose the work and its limits

Ask to spend up to $5,000 over two weeks to try both designs with five customers and get an Engineering estimate. Name who does each part. Those are fictional example amounts, not recommended defaults.

Explain what comes afterward

Bring the findings and estimate to Finance. Ask whether to fund the build, change the idea, or stop. Don't promise a finished service when you're only promising a customer test.

A useful commitment says what you'll do, who will do it, how much time or money you'll use, and when the other person will hear back.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Offer the next useful piece of certainty.

An honest limit can help someone plan. Work out which question you can answer next and what it will cost to find out.

1 / What do we already know?

Customers phone to book repairs. We have two sketches. Customers have not tried either. Explain those facts without dressing them up as a final design.

2 / What would change the decision?

Can customers complete a booking with either design? What would each take to build? Choose questions that affect whether to spend more.

3 / What are we asking to spend?

Name the people, time, money, and stopping point. In the fictional example, it is up to $5,000 over two weeks. Choose limits that fit your own situation.

4 / What will they get back?

Bring the customer findings, Engineering's assessment, and a recommendation. Explain what will still be uncertain and what decision comes next.

A small customer test can inform a choice. It cannot prove that everyone will use the product or that the whole business case is sound.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Say it as you would in the meeting.

Start with what they need. Then explain what you can offer and ask for the decision you need.

Show that you heard them

“You need a spending limit by Thursday.” Use the need they confirmed, rather than an explanation you invented.

Make a concrete offer

“Could we set aside up to $5,000 for two weeks to try both booking designs with five customers and check the build work with Engineering?”

Explain what they will get back

“We’ll bring you the results, an estimate, and a recommendation before asking you to pay for the full build.”

Ask for a response

“Would that give you enough to make Thursday's decision?” Let them tell you if the offer doesn’t meet their need. Revise it together.

Read the message aloud. If you would not say a phrase in conversation, find the words you would use.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Tell the team what the answer means.

An answer from Finance needs to reach the people doing the work. Before anyone books sessions or starts building, check that you all heard the same thing.

If they say yes

“Finance has agreed up to $5,000 for the two weeks of customer sessions and an estimate. They haven’t funded the build. Can we check who is doing each part and book our review?”

If they change the offer

“They can fund less than we asked for. What could we learn with that amount? Let’s check before I promise we can do the same work for less.”

If there is no answer yet

“I’m still waiting to hear. Please don’t book the paid sessions yet. I’ll follow up Thursday and let you know.”

Keep the written record current

Write down the actual answer and any conditions. If someone remembers it differently, check with the person who made the call before changing the work.

You can draft an update for Finance and a separate one for the team in the Lab. Edit them after the decision so a proposal doesn’t read like permission.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Keep working on the actual question.

Sometimes the first offer won't be enough. Ask what is missing.

"Just give me the date"

If the team has a reliable estimate for the agreed work, share it with its assumptions. Otherwise say what needs checking and when you can return with an estimate. Use Deadline Reset if a date has already been promised.

"We can't approve an open-ended budget"

Agree a maximum spend and a stopping point. Explain what that money buys and what will still be unknown. The person paying can change or decline the proposal.

"We need to tell the customer something"

Work with the person responsible for that customer. State what is available, what is still being checked, and when the next update will come. Check any existing contractual promise.

"Why does the plan keep changing?"

Explain what you learned and how it changed the plan. If you also missed something or didn't keep people updated, acknowledge that and agree how you'll keep them informed from here.

Try: "I want to give you something you can plan around. Which part of this still leaves you unable to make the decision?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Find out what the no is telling you.

A useful conversation can end without funding. You can understand the answer and decide what to do next without turning it into another sales pitch.

No money right now

“Is the problem the amount, or is there no budget for this at the moment?” If there is no budget, don’t quietly ask the team to do the work anyway.

Not this problem

“Is there something more important you need us to focus on?” You may have learned that the proposed service isn’t a priority. Check what that means for the current plan.

Not enough confidence yet

“What would you need to know before considering it?” Ask whether you already have that information or can find it within work that is approved.

A clear stopping point

“Okay. Shall we leave this here, or is there a specific change that would make it worth revisiting?” Record that answer. A polite maybe isn’t approval to keep spending.

You don’t have to rescue every proposal. Understanding a no can save people weeks of work and leave the relationship in good shape.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Finance needs a budget by Thursday.

Fictional example: the finance director asks for the final feature list for an online repair-booking service. Customers haven't tried either proposed design yet.

The product manager asks why

Finance needs a spending limit by Thursday. They don't need every screen agreed. The product manager checks that understanding before proposing a smaller first spend.

The proposed commitment

Propose spending up to $5,000 over two weeks to let five customers try both designs and ask Engineering what each would take to build. The product manager arranges the customer sessions; the engineering lead estimates the build work.

The reply

You need a budget by Thursday. Could we approve up to $5,000 for two weeks of customer testing first? Then we can show you which design works and what it would take to build before you commit to the full cost.

What happens next

In this example, Finance approves the limited spend on Thursday. The product manager books the customer sessions and the review two weeks later. Funding for the full build is still undecided. The Lab example starts before approval.

Finance can plan the immediate spend. The team knows what to test. Nobody has pretended that the final design or full delivery date is already known.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Bring the sentence you heard.

You can prepare the reply before the conversation and update it after you have checked what the other person needs.

The request

Record their words, who asked, and what they need to decide. The starter buttons can help you begin; edit the wording to match your situation.

What they need

Choose the reason they need an answer, record what they confirmed, and name anything you still need to check. Preview What They Need if you want to review your understanding.

What we can promise

Write what you know, what is still uncertain, and what you can offer now. Include the time, money, and other limits. Preview Proposed Commitment.

Your reply

Write the short spoken version if useful, then the message. Name the decision you need and when. Preview Your Reply as a proposal. Return after the conversation to record the answer and the next action.

Load Examples shows the fictional booking-service case. Use your own facts before sharing a document.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What happened after the conversation?

Once you have talked, come back and see what changed. What helped, what still needs attention, and who needs to hear from you?

Follow up

Bring the promised findings on the agreed date. Ask whether they helped the person make the decision. If you misunderstood the need or promised something too vague, revise the offer and check it with them.

Try saying it out loud

Read your message aloud. Does it sound like you? If a phrase feels awkward, use the words you'd say in the meeting. Someone you trust can help you spot anything that's hard to follow.

Keep the record

Copy, download, or print anything you need to keep. Shared answers save in this browser on this device; they don't follow you to another device. Private notes aren't saved. Export before clearing a draft or browser data.

Check what happened

Was the decision understood? Did someone act? Did the change help the people it was meant to help? If nobody responded, find out who can decide and agree when to ask again. Silence doesn't mean yes.

> You don't have to fix the whole organization in one conversation. Leave knowing what happens next, who will do it, and when you'll check back.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Make room for each other's judgment.

A good translation helps people think together. Notice whether the conversation changed your understanding as well as theirs.

Identity

Could you say what you did not know without feeling less capable? Could the other person ask for what they needed without being treated as the problem?

Relationship

Did asking why build understanding? What would make it easier for Finance, Sales, and the team to ask each other an unfinished question next time?

Vision

Did you find a result that matters to both of you? Can you explain how the proposed work helps customers and the person making the funding decision?

Culture

Do people now expect evidence and honest updates, or polished certainty? What habit could make the next planning conversation more useful?

Look at what changed for people as well as what was decided. You can reflect without recording or sharing personal details.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

1 / The words you heard

Finance asks for the final feature list before reserving next quarter's budget. The PM could argue about uncertainty, but first asks what Finance needs to decide.

Finance director

"Can you send me the final feature list? I need to set aside next quarter's budget."

PM

"Which decision do you need the list for? What has to be settled by Thursday?"

Ask yourself: What do you know about their need, and what have you only assumed?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

2 / Find the actual need

The finance director confirms that Thursday's need is a spending limit. Every screen does not need to be settled yet. The PM checks that understanding before making an offer.

Finance director

"I need to know how much to set aside. I don't need every screen chosen this week."

PM

"Would it help if we agreed a smaller amount now, then came back once we know more?"

Ask yourself: Would the other person recognize the need you have written down?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

3 / Start with a smaller commitment

The PM proposes up to $5,000 over two weeks to try both booking designs with five customers and get Engineering's assessment. These are fictional limits, not recommended defaults. The full build remains undecided.

PM

"Could we fund those two weeks first? We'll show you what customers made of it and what it would take to build before asking for the rest."

Finance director

"What would we be able to decide at the end, and what would still be uncertain?"

Ask yourself: Does the proposed work answer the question that affects the next investment?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

4 / Record the response

In this fictional continuation, Finance approves the limited work on Thursday. The PM records what the approval covers and books the review. This is not approval for the full service.

Finance director

“Yes, up to $5,000 for that. Come back and show me what you’ve learned before we spend anything on the build.”

PM

“Thanks. I’ll book a time for us to look at it together and let the team know what we’ve agreed.”

Ask yourself: Can the team tell exactly what is funded and what is still undecided?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

5 / Return with what you learned

The learning is less tidy than hoped: customers struggle with one part of booking, and Engineering finds another question. The PM returns when promised, explains that, and asks for the next decision without claiming the design is proven.

PM

“Here’s what we learned. I don’t recommend funding the whole build yet. These are the two questions I think we should answer next.”

Finance director

“Show me what that would take and what decision it would help us make.”

Ask yourself: Did you keep the promise to return, even though the answer was not the one you hoped for?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

ChapGPT schools me on leading well

Nic Payne · Article

Use Nic's reflection to meet the person behind the request rather than reducing them to a role that is getting in your way.

What pressure or responsibility might they be carrying that I have not asked about?

Take this into your Lab >

The Search For Unapologetic Impracticality In Leadership: Part I - What We Measure, And What It Hides

Nic Payne · Article

Consider what the conversation leaves out when it only asks for numbers and deliverables.

What are we learning about judgment and trust as we work this out?

Take this into your Lab >

Leadership: participating and being changed

Nic Payne · Video · start at 13:45

Nic's video asks you to participate and be changed by the conversation too.

What did their answer change in my understanding of the request?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

[You Have a Culture Problem]

Nic Payne · Article

See how a shared purpose and a better relationship can change the next planning conversation.

What worthwhile future can both of us help make possible?

[Take this into your Lab >]

[When Mattering Isn't Enough]

Nic Payne · Article

Explore how pressure to sound certain can affect people, and what an honest commitment could make possible instead.

Where are people carrying a cost because they cannot say what they still need to learn?

[Take this into your Lab >]

[Assumption Testing: Everything You Need to Know to Get Started]

Teresa Torres · Author's practical article

Choose a particular assumption to check before asking someone to fund a larger piece of work.

What finding would change our recommendation about the next investment?

[Take this into your Lab >]

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

Shape Up — Chapter 6: Write the Pitch

Ryan Singer · Book chapter

Use the problem, time limit, and boundaries to explain what your proposed work will and will not cover.

What are we asking to spend, what will we do, and where will we stop?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

The thinking behind the tool.

Holistic Shaping asks what work is doing to people, as well as what people are doing at work. These short notes connect the Guide to Nic's teaching and a few practical sources. Read what helps with the situation in front of you. Links open the original resources.

Back in the Guide

CHAPTER 01

Find out what their words mean to them.

In Nic's writing on shared language, a practical constraint can be a contribution to the idea. 'Final requirements' might mean Finance needs to know what funding would cover. Ask what decision the request serves before explaining your preferred way of working.

Worth asking: What do they need to decide, and what would help them decide it?

Stop Chasing Psychological Safety
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 02

Stay curious when the wording irritates you.

It is easy to hear a project word and prepare a lecture about Product. Notice the person using it. They have work, pressures, and responsibilities of their own. Nic's bowl metaphor asks what kind of attention we bring to the relationship and whether we leave room to be changed by it.

Worth asking: What might you understand if you let them finish explaining the request?

Leadership as bowl, water, and current
Nic Payne · Video · start at 4:19

Every leader needs contact lenses
Nic Payne · Substack Note

The Mirror Move
Nic Payne / Rebel Leaders · Codex practice

CHAPTER 04

Give uncertainty a useful next step.

You can make a real commitment without promising an answer you do not yet have. Say which question you will check, how, and by when. Teresa Torres's assumption-testing guide helps narrow that question. Nic's writing on certainty explains why a polished plan should not replace judgment.

Worth asking: Which belief must you check before asking people to commit to the whole build?

The Search For Unapologetic Impracticality In Leadership: Part II - The Seduction of Certainty
Nic Payne · Article

Assumption Testing: Everything You Need to Know to Get Started
Teresa Torres · Author's practical article

CHAPTER 05

Read your reply out loud.

“To lead differently, we must learn to speak a different language.”

Nic Payne · The words we use for people

Nic’s Note on the words we inherit asks us to notice when language hides the person. Name the customer waiting for a repair, the developer checking the change, and the colleague who needs a funding decision. If a sentence sounds like something nobody would say, rewrite it before sending.

Worth asking: Could the person receiving this explain what you are offering and what you need from them?

The words we use for people
Nic Payne · Substack Note

CHAPTER 06

Does your reply leave them able to participate?

Consider what repeated exchanges like this do to people. A correction can leave someone embarrassed and less willing to ask. A clear explanation can help both of you learn the work, make better judgments, and build trust. Be specific about what you can offer, and invite them to tell you what is still missing.

Worth asking: Can they question or change your proposal without being made to feel foolish?

When Mattering Isn’t Enough
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 09

Build a shared way to ask and answer.

After the immediate request, ask what you now understand about each other’s work. Keep the explanation and decision where the next person can find them. Cultural Orbital Mechanics helps trace how repeated encounters shape identity and relationship—and what becomes normal between teams.

Worth asking: Will the next request be easier because of what you learned together?

You Have a Culture Problem
Nic Payne · Article

Do Your Replacement a Favor
Nic Payne · Article

Explore more of Nic’s Holistic Shaping work at Rebel Leaders.

The notes apply the teaching to these situations. They are not quotations unless marked. The health reflection is optional; you do not need to record or share personal information.